



Discussion Guide: Mihee Kim-Kort

Mother Tongue

Reflect

- What does Mihee mean by the term “mother tongue”? Was your mother tongue different from the language you now speak?
- Mihee describes how her Korean parents had to “learn to be legible” after moving to the United States. Why do you think her parents felt compelled to give up their mother tongue? What is lost when individuals do so?
- Mihee argues that learning a mother tongue involves more than memorizing and repeating certain words. It is to participate in the preservation of one’s culture and identity. From a faith perspective, what would you affirm about the value of different groups preserving their unique culture and identity?

Respond

- Even if your native language is English, what are some unique phrases or terms you learned from your parents or grandparents while growing up? Do you still use them today? Why are they meaningful for you?
- What examples can you think of from the Gospels in which Jesus was “not proper” in terms of how he spoke or what he did? What rules did he break? What was the effect?
- What are some areas you would like to see your church begin to experiment with using theological or liturgical language in new ways? What benefits might there be to doing so?